

North Carolina Traffic Court Procedures

NORTH CAROLINA TRAFFIC COURT PROCEDURES

Court Appearance Requirements

- Mandatory appearance for certain violations
- Option to appear or pay fine for minor infractions
- 60 days to respond to citation
- Failure to appear results in license suspension
- Court dates cannot be rescheduled without cause

Plea Options

- Guilty plea: Accept responsibility and penalty
- Not guilty plea: Contest the charges
- No contest (nolo contendere): Accept penalty without admission
- Prayer for judgment continued (PJC)
- Deferred prosecution programs

Prayer for Judgment Continued

- Judge finds guilt but doesn't enter conviction
- No insurance or license points assessed
- Limited to one PJC per household every 3 years
- Not available for all violations
- Court costs still apply

Legal Representation

- Right to attorney for criminal charges
- Traffic attorneys specialize in violations
- Public defender for indigent defendants
- Self-representation allowed
- Attorney consultation recommended for serious charges